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Sacramento Snapshot: OC lawmakers of both parties consider violence prevention bills

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Editor's note: Sacramento Snapshot is a weekly series during the legislative session detailing what Orange County's representatives in the Assembly and Senate are working on — from committee work to bill passages and more.

This week's edition of Sacramento Snapshot is a little late.

The original plan was to highlight how Orange County legislators seek to tackle gun violence prevention this year, in a state deemed to have the strongest gun laws in the nation. But over the weekend, a gunman killed 10 people and injured 10 others at a Monterey Park dance hall, the nation's deadliest mass shooting since last year's Uvalde, Texas massacre.

The heinous and devastating attack on a nearby Los Angeles County community only underscores the gravity of the topic, the real implications of legislators' work in the Capitol as they reiterated their commitment to pass meaningful gun violence prevention bills this year following the mass shooting.

Sen. Catherine Blakespear, a Democrat who represents south Orange County communities, has already filed one spot bill — meaning the specifics and substance will get worked on as the legislative session gets more underway — that she said "will require all gun owners to buy an insurance policy so the results of gun violence aren't born by the victims." She said Sunday that the shooting, a few dozen miles north of the most northern part of her district, amplifies her efforts.

Assemblymember Laurie Davies, R-Laguna Niguel, recognized the bipartisan work on gun violence prevention the legislature accomplished last year but said Sunday that "more can be done." For her, that includes increased funding for California's APPS database that cross-references gun purchasers against other records to catch people who might be prohibited from owning a firearm.

Gov. Gavin Newsom's original budget proposal for 2023-24 includes $486 million in general funds for the Department of Justice. Davies suggested legislators may need to ask for a portion of that to go toward beefing up the APPS (Armed and Prohibited Persons System) database — as well as for California's gun violence restraining order protections — before the governor's office releases a revised budget plan based on the latest economic forecast in May.

"The money is there, it's just making sure it's going toward where it has to go," Davies said.

It's early in the legislative session, and many legislators are still working out the details of their bill packages for the year, including Sen. Dave Min, D-Irvine. A spokesperson for the senator confirmed he is "strongly considering" including some sort of gun violence prevention legislation to his slate this year.

Following the Monterey Park shooting, Min said: "There is no place left in America that is safe from gun violence. This has to stop. Enough is enough."

Assemblymember Tri Ta, R-Westminster, is behind a bill that would allow a judge to issue longer prison sentences for someone convicted of a felony with a firearm — a change to existing law that allows the court to reject a sentencing enhancement, or increased penalty, if it's "in the furtherance of justice to do so."

"This bill is critical to public safety as it will give judges the ability to enhance firearm-related sentences, keeping violent criminals behind bars," Ta said.

And Assemblymember Cottie Petrie-Norris, D-Irvine, is working with gun control groups like Moms Demand Action and Everytown for Gun Safety on potential legislation this year as well. "We need to continue to push for sensible gun laws to stop the violence," Petrie-Norris said Sunday.

There are other bills already proposed this year by lawmakers not representing Orange County. There's one from Assemblymember Damon Connolly, D-San Rafael, that would bar people from purchasing body armor unless their employment requires it. From Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, there is a bill to impose an excise tax on firearms and ammunition with the money earmarked for school safety measures. And there's another (cosponsored by Petrie-Norris and Sharon Quirk-Silva, D-Fullerton) that would allow Californians to voluntarily add themselves to the Do Not Sell List, barring them from being sold or given a gun.

Newsom, who visited Monterey Park on Sunday in the aftermath of the shooting, called for more federal action on gun control.

"No other country in the world is terrorized by this constant stream of gun violence," he said on social media. "We need real gun reform at a national level."

Just last year, the California Legislature passed legislation prohibiting the firearm industry from marketing products to minors and allowing gun makers to be sued if their products cause harm. And Min's bill prohibiting the sale of guns on state-owned property, including fairgrounds, went into effect on Jan. 1.

An average of 3,160 people in California die each year by guns, meaning the state has the 45th highest rate of gun deaths in the U.S., according to statistics from the nonprofit Everytown for Gun Safety.

Gun control advocates closed out the legislative session last year by praising the work the legislature did — and saying there is still more work to be done regarding gun safety in California. And just a few weeks into this year's legislative session, that call for action was symbolized by flags lowering to half-staff Monday at the White House and other public buildings across the nation and abroad, the result of a proclamation from the president "as a mark of respect for the victims of the senseless acts of violence."

In other news

Sen. Tom Umberg's Judiciary Committee held its first hearing of 2023, passing a resolution reaffirming California's commitment to reproductive health care, including abortion. The resolution was cosponsored by Blakespear, a Democrat from Encinitas.

Sen. Janet Nguyen, R-Huntington Beach, said Friday she's looking forward to working as vice chair of the Senate Health Committee with the chair, Sen. Susan Talamantes Eggman of Stockton, to address the homelessness crisis throughout the state.

Sen. Bob Archuleta, whose district includes Brea, and Petrie-Norris urged President Joe Biden to step in to end the blockade of what's called the Lachin corridor, the only supply route to ethnic Armenians in the Nagorno-Karabakh region, which has been blocked by crowds from Azerbaijan since mid-December, according to the Associated Press. The legislators noted California is home to a large diaspora of Armenian Americans whose families are impacted by the blockade.

Assemblymember Diane Dixon, R-Newport Beach, will serve as vice chair of the Local Government Committee as well as the Accountability and Administrative Review Committee this year. She said she will "be another voice of support to bring local control back to our communities" and is looking forward to working with Petrie-Norris on the A&AR committee to "review the effectiveness of state programs and agencies."

Davies was appointed vice chair of the Military Affairs & Veterans Committee. She will also sit on committees pertaining to transportation, governmental organization and parks and wildlife, among others.

Speaking of Davies, she is championing legislation this session that would require counties to use unmasked numbers when contacting people regarding social services programs. Orange County is one of several that restricts its number when calling current or potential recipients.

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